

It's hard to think of another area of life that touches virtually everyone whether they are married or single, young or old. It's amazing that for such a long time Christians have failed to see the relationship between handling finances and other areas of struggle.

2 MONEY: AN OUTSIDE INDICATOR

In the New Testament, Jesus draws an interesting parallel between the way that we handle our money and the way that we handle spiritual things in our lives. In fact, the way we handle our money is the best outside reflection of our true inner values. You can tell more about the spiritual lives of a couple by looking at their checkbook than by anything else. People can say anything they think others want to hear, and many people are great at faking their true attitudes, but the way they handle their finances is usually a dead giveaway to what is *really* going on.

One of the things I learned in counseling a long time ago is: always counsel a married couple together, because you'll get much better answers from two than you will from just one. Most people are usually somewhat self-conscious about their financial mistakes. As a result, they will tend to water down their abuses, particularly where debts are concerned. Also, since most couples are opposites, one tends to exaggerate, while the other has a very narrow sense of the truth. Between the two of them, the right balance can be found.

I was at my desk working on an upcoming conference one day a few years back when I received a call from an obviously distressed young woman named Becky.

"They're coming to repossess our home," she said. "Can you help us, please?"

It took me several minutes to get her calmed down enough to explain what was happening. It seemed her husband paid the bills (or was supposed to), but he was consistently negligent about details—such as mailing the checks! Almost every